As he drifted, he also found ways to offend the left. Arguably the *rotatzia*'s biggest success was the 1985 "economic stabilization plan", a series of emergency measures aimed at curbing hyperinflation (already above 400 per cent). The program cut the budget, devalued the shekel, and imposed a series of wage and price controls. It worked: the inflation rate plunged to less than 20 per cent within two years, though it would take until 1989 for the economy to start growing.

The socialist left still considers the program a betrayal of Peres' Labor roots, because it chipped away at Israel's welfare state and paved the way for privatization and other neoliberal reforms in the 1990s. Yet without those reforms, Israel's modern economy, and particularly its high-tech industry, would not exist. It used to take months, even years, to get a new phone line from Bezeq, the government-owned monopoly. The situation only improved after the market was opened to competition in the 1990s.

The rest of his career is well-known: the Nobel Peace Prize; his role in the peace process; and finally his seven-year period as the country's beloved president, a role that allowed him to bask in the spotlight. He created the President's Conference, a sort of Davos-on-the-Mediterranean that brought together politicians, business leaders and other influential types to discuss everything from politics to art. (The last one was in 2013; to nobody's surprise, Rivlin did not continue the tradition.) He traveled the world, meeting with everyone from heads of state to Mark Zuckerberg, the founder of Facebook. Obama awarded him the Presidential Medal of Freedom, America's highest civilian honor, in 2012.

He was, in other words, the liberal Zionist ideal made flesh, a man who escaped the flames of Europe for a pastoral life on the pre-state kibbutzim, then fought for his newly-established state—not with a rifle, but in his own way, he gave the Jewish homeland physical security. With that accomplished, he turned his attention to its moral security, its long-term destiny. By the end he was a myth, the ninety-three-year-old peacemaker of indomitable spirit who worked harder than his young aides. Admirers and critics would agree on one thing: Peres allowed Israel to show its ideal face to the world. "He was the Israel that everyone wanted it to be, rather than the country that actually is," Chemi Shalev wrote in *Ha'aretz* on the day he died.[23]

"He was what he wanted to be"